



A detail from the painting *Battle of Valmy*, by French artist Emile-Jean-Horace Vernet, shows Prussia's defeat by France.

EVENTS IN FRANCE TOOK A

DRAMATIC TURN on April 20, 1792 when the National Assembly declared war on the Holy Roman Empire, perceiving it as a threat. Emperor Leopold II had signed the **Declaration of Pilnitz** with Frederick William II of Prussia, swearing to defend Louis XVI and destroy Paris should anything befall him. Provoked by the French call to war, Austrian and Prussian troops set off for France.

News of this enraged the French people, who thought they had been betrayed by their king and the aristocracy, and on August 10 a group of revolutionaries found **Louis XVI** when they stormed the **Tuileries Palace**. The king and the rest of the royal family were **jailed in the Temple** prison.

By early September, fears that royalist prisoners were organizing a counter-revolutionary plot were

growing, and on September 2 an armed group of Parisians attacked and killed some prisoners who were being transferred to a different jail. This set off a wave of action, known as the **September Massacres**, in which angry mobs in Paris and elsewhere took suspects from prison and executed them. Around **1,200** people were killed in five days.

The war began with setbacks for France, but by September 20, the French successfully held off the Prussians at the **Battle of Valmy**, in northeastern France, then attacked the Austrian Netherlands winning a victory at **Jemappes** in what is now Belgium. In Paris, a new ruling body, the **National Convention**, met and the following day abolished the constitutional monarchy in favor of establishing a **republic**.

142.5
MILLION

1783–84

285
MILLION

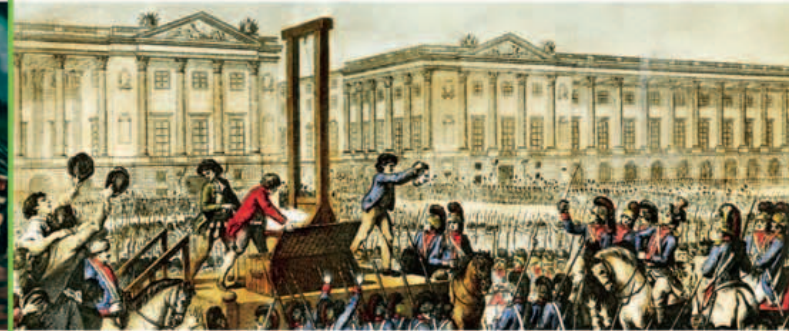
1792–93

Tea export

The British public's taste for tea became evident, as the pounds of tea the East India Company exported from China doubled.

By this point the rest of Europe was concerned about events within France and its boldness beyond its borders, so Holland, Spain, Austria, Prussia, and Russia established the **First Coalition**, with Britain joining in 1793. They fought against France throughout the following six years during the **War of the First Coalition**.

Meanwhile, halfway across the world, the East India Company had found that supplying the British with **Chinese tea**—for which they were paying China in opium produced in Bengal—was proving a profitable trade. Exports doubled in a decade as the hot drink became popular in Britain and North America. Conducting business with China, however, was complicated for the Company. It was only allowed commercial access through one port, **Canton** (Guangzhou), as the Chinese kept strict controls on the entry of foreigners to the rest of the country.



This image shows the execution of Louis XVI by guillotine in the Place de la Révolution, Paris. His wife Marie Antoinette was executed a few months later.

ON JANUARY 18, THE NATIONAL CONVENTION OF FRANCE

condemned Louis XVI to death. On January 21 he was taken to the Place de la Révolution, Paris, where he was guillotined. His wife, **Marie Antoinette**, remained in prison until October, when she appeared before a Revolutionary tribunal. She met the same fate as her husband on October 16.

Marie Antoinette's death occurred during the **Reign of Terror**, which was the result of a decree on September 5 that made "terror" the means of governance. A couple of weeks later the **Law**

of Suspects was passed, which established **Revolutionary Tribunals**. Anyone suspected of being an enemy of the Revolution was tried and if deemed guilty received a death sentence. The activities of hundreds of thousands of people were monitored, and many were arrested. The **Committee of Public Safety**, led by **Maximilien**

Eli Whitney's cotton gin

This machine separated cotton seeds from the plant's fiber more quickly than if done by hand, which increased cotton production greatly.



MARY WOLLSTONECRAFT (1759–97)

Mary Wollstonecraft was an English writer and early advocate for women's rights. Deeply influenced by events in France and subsequent debates in Britain, she published, *A Vindication on the Rights of Woman*, in 1792. The work, calling for the education system to allow girls the same advantages as boys, was controversial. It would be many years before any changes were enacted, but the book has endured as a work of early feminist philosophy.



March 16 Attempted assassination of Gustavus III of Sweden, who dies from his wounds on March 16, 1746

April 20 War of the First Coalition (to 1797): France declares war on Holy Roman Empire, Prussia, and Piedmont

April 25 French national anthem, *La Marseillaise*, composed by Claude-Joseph Rouget de Lisle

September 21 France abolishes monarchy and declares itself a republic

January 21 Louis XVI is executed

January 23 Second partition of Poland

English writer Mary Wollstonecraft (1759–1797) publishes *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*

September Sonthonax arrives in Saint-Domingue to quell slave rebellion

Denmark abolishes the slave trade

February Second Nootka Convention signed by Britain and Spain

France declares war on Britain, the Dutch Republic, and Spain; Britain enters fighting in Saint-Domingue